The incredible story of a turnaround

Meghalaya, blessed with immense natural beauty and resources, is one of India's smallest states—22nd in terms of area and 24th in population. Yet, the north-eastern state, which shares international border with Bangladesh, is unique in many ways. With an average annual rainfall of 1,150 cm, Meghalaya, which literally means abode of cloud, receives the highest amount of rainfall in the country. Recognised as a state of Indian Union, it may be just 50-year-old, but in 2018, the International Commission on Stratigraphy, which has divided the Holocene epoch into three subdivisions, named the late Holocene as the Meghalayan age. A speleothem in Mawmluh cave, which indicates, a dramatic worldwide climate event around 2250 BCE, has been chosen as the boundary stratotype.

The year 2018 also saw another change in Meghalaya—Conrad K. Sangma, only 40-year-old then, took charge of the state. It was a baptism by fire for the son of former Lok Sabha speaker PA Sangma, the most illustrious political leader from the north-east. The state was reeling under economic distress, corruption, socio-political frictions, and a collective sense of despair. Armed with a management degree from the prestigious Imperial College in United Kingdom, Chief Minister Conrad Sangma hit the ground running and set his priorities—sector-specific policies for economic development and ensuring their speedy execution.

Chief Minister Conrad Sangma created task forces for formulating policies on education, telecom, youth, and sports. The objective was to frame policies considering the concerns of all stakeholders. Several policies, including on industries and tourism, were revisited. Every area of growth was spotted and encouraged. The microscopic focus was evident from the beginning.

To fundamentally transform the agriculture sector, his government launched a scheme termed FOCUS (Farmers Collectivization for Upscaling Production and Marketing System). This flagship initiative for the state's producers envisages the bottom-up collectivization of producers into groups. The producer groups are provided an amount of Rs 5,000 per producer as a group corpus for increasing production and productivity. This programme is a firm step to empower the farmers of Meghalaya so that they can come together and solve their immediate problems. Within a year, the programme has been a grand success. It currently covers almost 19,000 producer groups comprising 2,50,000 families, 330 cooperative societies and about 80 aggregation and processing centres. Hundreds of success stories are emerging from the FOCUS program.

Taking inspiration from the success and demand of the FOCUS programme, CM Sangma's government recently launched the FOCUS+ programme. Under this, an unconditional and untied annual cash benefit of R. 5,000 is being provided to each producer household to take any farm production-related activity. With the FOCUS and the FOCUS+ programmes, each rural household will receive a cash benefit of Rs 10,000 per annum.

Another focus is on horticulture. Even though Meghalaya is known for its horticulture, the state never had a food processing directorate. Sangma created one and sanctioned Rs 80 crore for our first project the Jackfruit Mission.

The administration, from top to bottom, was given categorical objectives—ensuring livelihoods for all, building infrastructure for growth, nurturing the youth and children, empowering women, providing good governance and welfare to all, and making Meghalaya one of the top 10 states in the country in next 10 years, in in GSDP per capita and SDG ranking. Several departments were restructured to create synergy and ensure faster delivery. But more importantly, what Chief Minister Conrad Sangma wanted to achieve first was taking the fruits of development to every citizen of Meghalaya. *"Development has no meaning if it is not inclusive. Every citizen must be equal stakeholder in the process. In these last four years, we haven't left any section of the society behind. We are committed to include all the sections of the society and facilitate in their physical and social well-being,"* says Conrad Sangma.

It was a highly challenging journey, made even more difficult by Covid pandemic which hit the state, along with the rest of the world, in 2020. The flight to growth, prosperity and social justice came to a grinding halt as mankind began fighting back the onslaught of an invisible virus. But there was no scope to pause for long.

Meghalaya followed a unique collaborative approach in dealing with the Covid challenges, by involving the community leaders, localities, religious institutions and above all the people of the state. While the state government upgraded the infrastructure of several health facilities on war-footing, it fundamentally introduced a new model—"Behaviour Change Model for living with COVID-19"—which involves treating every resident as an asymptomatic carrier of the virus. An order was issued to treat everyone in the state as "Category 'A' patients unless they are tested on a continuous basis. The 'Category A' patient had to follow three non-negotiable practices: compulsory mask-wearing, hand hygiene and social distancing. This practice involved vigilant de-centralized monitoring by the communities. Hence, people in the state could perform their usual livelihood activities. In the pandemic year alone, Meghalaya witnessed a never seen before growth in rural roads—2.2 km roads were constructed every day.

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> Chief Minister, Meghalaya

Even as the collective battle against the lethal virus continues, Meghalaya and the world limped back to what can be called "normal". The "engine" for development was re-ignited and the programmes and policies to resolve the various unmet needs of the different sections of the society were put on fast track.

This year, as the state celebrates 50 years of statehood, the momentous occasion provides an opportunity to showcase the unprecedented socio-economic development Meghalaya witnessed in last four years under the leadership of Chief Minister Conrad Sangma. And the backbone of this developmental journey has been good governance. *"We are building a brand Meghalaya on which every citizen can capitalize and benefit. Together, we have taken significant strides in the development of the state through collaborative governance, decisive leadership, and determination,"* says Conrad Sangma.

And the results are showing. The government has provided rural employment to a greater number of people and financially empowered more women than ever before. It has provided improved and innovative health care, ensured safe and uninterrupted supply of water and electricity, and implemented specific programmes for prosperity and welfare of our farmers. The youth in Meghalaya now have more facilities and opportunities. Efforts were made to decentralise the power structure so that people could participate in the process of development at the grassroots level. The change is visible across all categories—infrastructure development, healthcare, education, power generation, job creation, women empowerment,